

PROJECT SYNDICATE DIGEST

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1. The Digital Choices Shaping our Children's Health

Author: Emmanuel Macron

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PARIS/GENEVA— From social media and online gaming to generative AI systems, digital environments are powerful determinants of people's health. That is especially true of children and young people. Around the world, childhood is being reprogrammed by digital technologies that shape how young people learn, play, and connect.

Our task is not to celebrate or condemn technology. It is to face a simple truth: our digital environment not only promises far-reaching benefits but also poses grave risks for children's health and development. Our responsibility is to maximize the first while preventing the second. It is not too late to act, but it is too late for merely incremental adjustments.

Digital tools can expand opportunity by supporting learning, communication, and access to health services, especially for children in remote or crisis-affected settings. For many young people, online spaces also offer creativity, community, and belonging, particularly for those facing exclusion offline.

But these benefits are not guaranteed; they depend heavily on who has access, how technologies are designed, and whose interests they serve.

Governments are increasingly recognizing that protecting children online is a public-health imperative. Australia has implemented the world's first requirement that social-media platforms prevent children under 16 from holding accounts, while France is advancing legislation to prohibit access to social media for those under 15. Indonesia has banned access for children under 16, Spain has announced plans to do so, and Ireland is working with European Union partners to develop age restrictions and age-assurance systems focused on protecting under-16s.

The United Kingdom, too, recently announced plans to ban social-media platforms from offering services to under-16s, alongside additional safeguards like restrictions on livestreaming and contacts from strangers. And Canada has introduced legislation to restrict access to social media for children under 16 while requiring stronger safety-by-design protections and accountability from platforms.

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Together, these measures reflect a growing global consensus that digital environments require effective governance, age-appropriate design, and stronger safeguards to protect child health. The World Health Organization is supporting this by strengthening the research needed to develop a clearer understanding of the impact of today's and tomorrow's technologies, providing technical advice to countries, and promoting safe, equitable digital health environments.

Solutions are needed because digital environments are not neutral. How they are designed, governed, and monetized shapes many aspects of our lives, not least our health.

For example, repeated exposure to stereotyped, sexualized, violent, or discriminatory content shapes how children understand themselves and the world around them. Algorithms increasingly filter health information to increase attention rather than accuracy, allowing misleading claims to spread. The collection and use of personal data, particularly for profiling and targeted marketing, raise concerns about privacy, manipulation, and well-being.

Current evidence associates excessive digital exposure with problems such as anxiety, depression, poor sleep, increased aggression, and, in more severe cases, suicidality, especially among vulnerable adolescents. Digital marketing on platforms may expose people to promotion of harmful products, such as tobacco, alcohol, and gambling platforms.

Social media, gaming, and AI use can deepen loneliness and displace offline relationships. Prolonged use contributes to sedentary behavior and reduced sleep, which are known risk factors for noncommunicable diseases.

Online sexual exploitation and abuse are also increasing globally, alongside a sharp rise in child sexual abuse material, AI-generated abuse imagery, and deepfake sexual or bullying content. These have profound and lasting consequences for mental health, trust, and safety.

Commercial practices increase all these risks. Many platforms are designed to maximize engagement, without adequate protection from exposure to harmful content or features to protect children's physical and mental health.

Reducing exposure to illegal or extreme and graphic content is essential. But children's well-being requires more than the absence of harm. It depends on stable relationships, appropriate boundaries, physical activity, and opportunities for real-world social connection. Risks multiply when digital environments disrupt—rather than support—healthy development.

Generative AI is a major force multiplier in terms of both risks and opportunities for child well-being. Used responsibly, purpose-built AI tools may support education, accessibility, and health. But their long-term impact on children's expectations of relationships, empathy, or self-regulation are unclear. As long as that remains true, a precautionary approach is not anti-innovation. It is pro-child.

Digital balance is part of the solution. While digital environments require regulation, transparency, age-appropriate design, stronger safety and trust features, and accountability, evidence must keep pace with technology, requiring independent, longitudinal research across income settings and regions.

Above all, we must listen to today's youth. As active users of technology, they can help digital environments evolve responsibly. The online and offline worlds now form a single space where digital tools can support healthy development—or crowd it out. Young people should bring their own lived experiences to bear in order to help shape appropriate guardrails. Parents, caregivers, schools, and communities must also be part of this conversation.

This process demands sustained collaboration across governments, industry, civil society, and public-health institutions, built on a shared commitment to maximizing benefits and minimizing harms. More transparency, data sharing, health-promoting design choices, and corporate support for effective safety standards, especially for minors, are essential. The WHO can play its convening role and influence in setting norms and standards.

Our children and young people are not experimental subjects, a captive market, or a commodity. Together, we can and must shape digital environments that protect and support their healthy development. The choices we

make now will echo for generations.

2. The Real Threat to NATO

Author: Ahmet Davutoğlu

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ISTANBUL—As NATO prepares for its July 7–8 summit in Ankara, the alliance faces a bigger challenge than either Russia or China: its members no longer share a coherent understanding of the values, economic order, geopolitical vision, and legal principles it was created to defend.

Every enduring military alliance ultimately hinges on a deceptively simple question: What is it defending? Without a clear answer, it becomes reactive, defining itself by its adversaries rather than by a common purpose.

When NATO was founded in 1949, that purpose was clear. Emerging from the devastation of World War II, the alliance was established to defend what its founders called the “free world” against Soviet expansionism. More fundamentally, it sought to preserve a liberal international order built on four mutually reinforcing pillars: democratic governance, economic openness, the West’s geopolitical primacy, and international law based on the United Nations Charter.

Today, each of these foundations is under strain. Nowhere is this more evident than in the alliance’s political identity, weakened by democratic backsliding and rising authoritarianism. NATO may remain the world’s most powerful military bloc, but its moral legitimacy depends on whether its members continue to embody the democratic values they espouse.

The response of many NATO governments to Israel’s military campaign in Gaza has exposed the widening gap between the alliance’s stated values and its members’ policies. While the International Court of Justice and the International Criminal Court continue to examine allegations of genocide and other grave violations of international law, several leading NATO members—most notably the United States—continue to provide the Israeli government with political support and political cover.

But an alliance whose historical legitimacy is rooted in the postwar rejection of fascism and genocide cannot afford to appear selective in its defense of universal humanitarian principles. Moral consistency is not an ethical luxury; it is a strategic asset that NATO abandons at its peril.

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The liberal economic order is also under growing pressure. Ironically, its greatest challenge has come not from NATO’s adversaries but from its own members, as protectionism, tariff wars, and the politicization of international trade have undermined the rules-based system that Western countries spent decades building and sustaining after 1945.

Meanwhile, the global economy’s center of gravity has shifted decisively toward Asia. When NATO was established, its members accounted for roughly two-thirds of world GDP. Their share has since fallen to less than half as Asia has emerged as the global economy’s principal growth engine.

The third pillar of the postwar order—geopolitical leadership—has become equally fragile. The Cold War provided NATO with a clear strategic framework. After the Soviet Union's collapse, however, the assumption that US predominance would endure became conventional wisdom, underpinning successive rounds of NATO enlargement and reinforcing the belief that military superiority alone could shape international outcomes.

The war in Afghanistan exposed the limits of that assumption. Following the September 11, 2001, attacks on the US, NATO undertook the largest and longest military operation in its history. Yet despite two decades of overwhelming military and technological superiority, the Taliban returned to power. The lesson was not that force had become irrelevant, but that battlefield success cannot substitute for political strategy. Lasting security requires diplomacy, institution-building, regional engagement, and long-term political vision.

That lesson is even more relevant in today's multipolar landscape. While deterrence remains indispensable, Cold War frameworks no longer fit a world shaped by economic coercion, migration, energy insecurity, technological competition, and cyber warfare. NATO must therefore complement military strength with geopolitical foresight and sophisticated statecraft.

Europe's own strategic contradiction has become increasingly difficult to ignore. Ukraine, the Black Sea, and the Middle East now form a single, interconnected zone of instability, yet the European Union continues to exclude the one country positioned at the crossroads of all three: Turkey.

A Europe seeking strategic autonomy cannot afford to remain strategically fragmented. Finland and Sweden's accession strengthened NATO's northern flank, but Europe's southern security architecture now depends on integrating Turkey into the EU's political institutions as well as its security ones.

Lastly, the international legal order is increasingly giving way to great-power politics. The credibility of any alliance rests on its willingness to uphold the norms it proclaims. Yet US President Donald Trump's threats to take over Greenland—an autonomous territory of Denmark—challenged one of the UN Charter's core principles: the territorial integrity of sovereign states. When NATO's leading power threatens the sovereignty of one of its own members, the alliance's commitment to international law rings hollow.

These structural challenges are compounded by a widening rift over NATO's strategic purpose. To be sure, disagreements among allies are not new. The Iraq War, for example, deeply divided the US and its European partners, but both sides continued to regard NATO as indispensable for transatlantic security. Today's disagreements are more fundamental. Under Trump, the US has increasingly treated NATO as a transactional arrangement, making major foreign-policy decisions without consulting key allies.

The Iran war is a case in point. The conflict, which could reshape the regional security landscape and has profoundly disrupted the global economy, carries profound implications for every NATO member, yet the alliance itself appears to have played no role in the decision-making process. An alliance whose members can be drawn into a regional conflict they neither collectively chose nor politically endorsed risks undermining the mutual trust required for security cooperation.

Given that NATO's crisis is one of identity rather than capability, revitalizing it requires more than higher defense budgets or stronger deterrence. NATO needs a renewed normative foundation grounded in democratic legitimacy and human rights, a recommitment to international law, and an economic vision suited to an era of shifting global power.

These must not be regarded as separate agendas. Without a coherent strategic philosophy centered on democratic legitimacy, human rights, and the rule of law, NATO risks becoming little more than an instrument of shifting national interests. The alliance's future ultimately depends less on the external threats it confronts

than on its ability to redefine what the transatlantic community stands for and what, ultimately, it seeks to defend.

3. There Is Only One Acceptable Path for Designer Babies

Author: Daron Acemoglu

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BOSTON—Designer babies who are genetically engineered for desirable health, physical, and intellectual features are now within reach using existing technologies, a prospect that raises far-reaching societal and ethical questions not unlike those associated with advances in AI. One difference, though, is that the institutions needed to open an ethical path for gene editing—by treating the technology as a public-health measure that should be available to everyone—may be easier to conceive than in the case of AI.

The big breakthrough for gene editing is no longer so recent. The outlook changed fundamentally back in the 2000s, and especially the early 2010s, with the development of CRISPR-Cas9 technology, which enables high-precision genetic engineering. The technique uses a guide RNA to locate a specific sequence in the genome of a living organism, where the Cas9 enzyme makes a cut for disabling or editing a gene.

The applications are vast. The technique can be used to turn off a disease-inducing gene, modify seeds and agricultural products, or design custom-made medicines and vaccines. It holds the potential to tackle inherited genetic diseases such as sickle cell anemia, as well as later-in-life, disease-inducing somatic mutations like those involved in cancer. It also raises the possibility of adding or removing genes at the embryonic stage, in vivo or in vitro, which is where the issue of designer babies comes in. Human genetic engineering could be purely somatic (affecting individuals during their lifetimes) or it could take the form of germline editing, altering the genome in ways that would be passed on to offspring.

AI itself is technologically complementary to gene editing, because it can sift through massive amounts of data to find gene combinations capable of changing not just disease potential, but looks, physical strength, and various dimensions of cognitive ability. But this potential raises obvious ethical issues. As in Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World*, designer babies could bring us closer to a genetically tiered society, where only the wealthy have the means to improve their and their progeny's cognitive and physical performance and lifespans. In this scenario, those with the money today could grow even richer and more genetically superior with each generation.

This scenario is not merely hypothetical. Embryo-selection services based on polygenic screening are already sold commercially to IVF patients, and advances in AI have made them even more enticing to those who can afford them. If current trends continue, we could end up with a cadre of billionaires and trillionaires who are intent on cementing their economic privileges with biological ones; worse, this could happen just as many other people are facing the prospect of AI-driven job displacement.

To prevent such a future, most people's first instinct is to ban germline editing and designer babies altogether. But this may not be the right response. After all, we already "design" our bodies and our children by means of vaccines and operations. Parents-to-be in the industrialized world (and increasingly in emerging economies) test for a variety of diseases, such as Down Syndrome, and can opt to terminate the pregnancy. The line between these interventions and genome editing is not hard and fast. Would editing genes to build natural immunity against smallpox be so different than injecting children with a vaccine?

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The issue isn't so much about "interfering with nature" as it is about two other considerations. First, the implications of germline editing are poorly understood. Living organisms are constantly attacked by pathogens, and some genetic changes, especially those passed from parents to offspring, can create unforeseen vulnerabilities.

For example, the Chinese scientist He Jiankui created the first designer babies by editing the CCR5 gene to confer HIV resistance. But the same edit appears to increase susceptibility to other infections, such as West Nile virus and influenza. We know what smallpox vaccines do, both because of their simplicity and because we have more than two centuries of experience. But the same cannot be said of the far more complex and intrusive process of genome editing.

Second, vaccines are a public-health intervention, whereas genome editing, at least in the foreseeable future, will be available only to the privileged, who will propagate their advantages in ways that we have not yet imagined.

These two issues point to a clear set of guidelines for how we should approach germline editing. First, we must make certain that unforeseen consequences are limited in number and scope. This requires not just research by individual scientists and labs, but also public infrastructure to provide a rigorous testing and permission process that is even more stringent than what the US Food and Drug Administration (FDA) requires for drugs and vaccines.

Second, we must legislate and enforce the norm that germline editing should be treated solely as a public-health measure. No germline editing services should be purchasable in the private market, and any well-tested, fully understood genome-engineering intervention that does prove beneficial should be made available to all.

Implementing such guidelines isn't pie in the sky. We already have highly respected institutions with the relevant expertise, and norms within the scientific community are aligned with these bodies. The US National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine and the FDA have both already published widely circulated reports and guidelines for research and practice in this area. Moreover, the 2015 International Summit on Human Gene Editing—which was convened by the US, British, and Chinese academies—adopted a hard line against germline engineering, especially the alteration of gametes and embryos that would generate heritable advantages for the privileged few. Subsequent summits in Hong Kong (2018), where the He case broke, and London (2023) then reaffirmed and refined that stance.

The fact that such bodies exist and have taken a proactive stand helps to explain why I see the challenge posed by designer babies as being somewhat more manageable than those associated with AI. The tragedy with AI is that we are on the cusp of similarly transformative developments, but with no equivalent bodies. Recently established AI safety institutes and European Union bodies lack the authority to influence the industry, and many individual scientists and labs remain oblivious to the societal effects that they may unleash.

We urgently need to build an ethical consensus on AI, not least because doing so could help us deal with the various symbiotic challenges that genetic engineering brings. Failing that, we will have traded future generations' inheritance for a mess of pottage.

4. The Democratic Turkey NATO Needs

Author: Özgür Özel **Published:** Jul 6, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

ANKARA—When NATO leaders arrive in Ankara for their annual summit on July 7–8, they will be meeting in a country whose strategic importance is unquestioned, but whose democratic foundations are fracturing. Recep Tayyip Erdoğan has governed Turkey for more than two decades—longer than any elected leader in the history of the Turkish Republic.

Today, Turkey stands at an inflection point. Given the country's increasingly centralized and personalistic rule since 2003, the question is no longer whether change is needed, but whether citizens will be allowed to pursue it freely and fairly through democratic means.

With Turkey's immediate region riven by wars and instability extending from Ukraine to the Middle East, it is clear to almost every Turkish citizen that their country's future matters not only to them, but to global security. At the same time, many people in Turkey are fearful of their future, having lost confidence in a government that has struggled to provide economic stability, predictable governance, and confidence in public institutions. Inflation has devastated household incomes. Young people increasingly see limited opportunities. Foreign policy has become more transactional and less predictable. Confidence in the judiciary, the rule of law, and public institutions has steadily eroded.

The key question confronting Turkey today is one of legitimacy. Governments can sometimes survive economic downturns. But they struggle when citizens stop believing the political system is fair. Rather than competing on a level playing field, Erdoğan has increasingly relied on state institutions, particularly the judiciary, to weaken political rivals and preserve his hold on power.

Voters in Turkey have already signaled their desire for change. In the 2024 local elections, our party, the Republican People's Party (CHP), emerged as Turkey's leading political force. Rather than accepting the message delivered by voters, the government intensified pressure on its political opponents.

Our party's presidential candidate, Istanbul Mayor Ekrem İmamoğlu, who has defeated Erdoğan-backed candidates repeatedly in Turkey's largest city, has been imprisoned. More than 30 opposition mayors remain behind bars in pre-trial detention. Prosecutors are seeking a cumulative sentence measured not in years but in millennia. The government has even attempted to invalidate our party convention years after it was held in an effort to reshape the leadership of the main opposition. The distinction between legal process and political intervention has become increasingly difficult to discern.

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In the days preceding the NATO summit, the government's increasingly defensive posture has been obvious. Authorities detained hundreds of innocent people in Ankara in sweeping operations ahead of the gathering. Officials describe these as anti-terrorism measures. Yet in a country where judicial independence has been severely weakened, such claims inevitably invite scrutiny. Reports indicate that those detained include activists, lawyers, journalists, academics, environmentalists, and elderly citizens.

The effort to manage appearances extended beyond arrests. Screens and barriers erected along parts of the route from the airport to the city center, reportedly to obscure visible signs of economic hardship, reveal a government more concerned with controlling perceptions than addressing underlying problems.

Erdoğan seeks to portray Turkey as stable, confident, and essential to Western security. At the Ankara summit he will emphasize Turkey's geopolitical importance while presenting himself as indispensable in navigating an increasingly turbulent region. Yet governments secure in their legitimacy rarely feel compelled to treat peaceful dissent, civic activism, or the possibility of protest as threats to public order.

Merely holding power does not confer legitimacy. Erdoğan retains control of the state and its machinery, but his increasing reliance on judicial pressure, administrative coercion, and the seizure of businesses, institutions, and assets rather than democratic consent has cost him the confidence of millions of citizens.

This model of rule cannot be sustained indefinitely. Turkey has become deeply polarized and increasingly exhausted—socially, economically, and politically. The demand for democratic accountability has not disappeared. It has merely been deferred.

Turkey's strategic importance is not in dispute. Its importance, both to NATO and within its region, stems not from its ability to solve every crisis, but from its position at the center of many of them—from Russia's war against Ukraine to the instability stretching from Syria to Iran.

For that reason, Turkey's political trajectory is not merely a domestic matter. A country of nearly 90 million people, a major military power, and a pivotal NATO member cannot indefinitely separate political legitimacy from national stability. Repression may create the appearance of order, but it cannot produce durable security.

Turkey's allies must learn to look beyond the current government and the disorder it has caused, and engage not only with those who hold power today but also with the democratic future they no longer credibly represent. Governments and leaders come and go. Turkey and its people endure. And Turkey's people are determined to build a country that is free and democratic at home, reliable abroad, and fully committed to the rule of law. That is the Turkey we are preparing to build: prosperous, confident in its institutions, and a strong, constructive actor in international peace and security.

5. How the EU Can Lead the Rest of the West

Author: Daniel Gros **Published:** Jul 6, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

MILAN—At the World Economic Forum’s 2026 meeting in Davos, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney described a “rupture” in the world order and called on middle powers to “act together.” Whereas great powers can afford (for now) to “go it alone” in this new Hobbesian world, he warned, middle powers must come to the table or risk being “on the menu.” But while some might see the European Union as a natural partner for such efforts, it appears to view itself as something more.

Rather than rallying partners from around the world, the EU has spent recent months asserting its economic might, which is formidable: though the European economy is somewhat smaller than those of the United States and China, it is several times larger than those of Japan, the United Kingdom, and India. Moreover, it is seeking to strengthen its own sovereignty, from the digital sphere to defense. This is not a bloc that is eager to settle for “middle power” status.

This response is wrongheaded. While Europe is not just another middle power, nor is it a “great power,” which Carney defines as having the “market size, the military capacity, and the leverage to dictate terms” on the global stage, particularly when dealing with an extractive US and a coercive China. But Europe is the ideal candidate to lead the group of like-minded middle powers that Carney envisioned, not as a US-style hegemon, but as a *primus inter pares* (first among equals).

The list of potential partners is long. The closest ones are Switzerland, Norway, and the UK. But Canada and, farther away, Australia, Japan, and South Korea are also good candidates, as they are high-income, stable democracies that are typically aligned with the EU on issues related to multilateral rule-setting, supply-chain resilience, and digital governance. A group comprising these countries and the EU would boast a GDP larger than that of the US and combined manufacturing output close to that of China.

But such a group cannot spontaneously organize itself. The EU should thus act as a catalyst and leader of a Compact for Open and Resilient Economies (CORE). The first step is to convene a summit in Brussels focused on producing a pledge (a formal treaty is unnecessary to start) to consult one another before taking trade or industrial-policy decisions that might have a significant impact on other CORE countries.

The EU, in particular, would commit to solicit feedback from its partners before enacting relevant legislation. Moreover, it would allow CORE countries to participate (without voting) in some of the many working and expert groups that hash out the details of legislative and other proposals. The EU would make final decisions independently, according to its own internal procedures.

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The EU’s structure can accommodate such an informal and flexible arrangement. As Article 217 of the EU Treaty states, the “Union may conclude with one or more third countries or international organizations agreements establishing an association involving reciprocal rights and obligations, common action and special procedure.” Agreements with close EU neighbors, such as Switzerland, reflect this principle. A more formal,

albeit narrower, precedent exists in the field of research, with a number of non-EU countries participating in Horizon Europe as “associate members,” which contribute funding and help to design research programs.

Nonetheless, to make the CORE work, the EU would have to change some of its policies. Consider the Industrial Accelerator Act (IAA), proposed by the European Commission this past March. The IAA calls for giving preferential treatment to goods made in the EU—following the lead of China and the US—in order to avoid losing its industrial base to predatory competition. But the bloc’s share of global industrial output amounts to only about 15% (and declining), meaning that reshoring entire supply chains will be next to impossible.

A “made with Europe” approach, which treats inputs from CORE countries as equivalent to European goods, avoids this problem. After all, the CORE not only covers a much larger economic area; its potential members possess capabilities and resources the EU lacks. Australia and Canada have raw materials; South Korea produces chips; and Switzerland is a leader in biotech. A made with Europe strategy would also strengthen goodwill among partners whose combined markets remain vital for EU exporters.

One might argue that inputs from within the EU will always be more reliable than those coming from third countries. But the risk of supply interruptions from like-minded partners is minimal. The CORE countries would be aligned with the EU economically and geopolitically, recognizing that, acting alone, their leverage at the global level is minimal.

Another issue the EU would need to address is its new, highly restrictive regime for steel imports. As it stands, the new rules, which cut the quotas for tariff-free imports by half and double the tariff to 50%, apply even to like-minded trading partners with which the EU has free-trade agreements (except Norway). This should change, with CORE countries exempted from the new regime.

More broadly, the CORE would avoid such disruptive unilateral action by ensuring that consultation begins in a policy’s design phase. At the very least, this would help to minimize any decision’s disruptive effects on other CORE economies, whose goodwill is important for Europe. It might even open the door for more effective joint action that benefits all parties.

Europe faces a choice: either narrow its ambitions to a limited notion of sovereignty and an impossible vision of a solitary industrial revival, or lead the way in building a community of open, resilient, and like-minded economies. The goal is not to replace the US as global hegemon—an outcome that is neither possible nor desirable for the EU. Rather, it is to offer something our world of extractive superpowers badly needs: leadership without domination.

6. Europe Must Face the World on Its Own

Author: Joschka Fischer

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BERLIN—As the United States withdraws from Europe under President Donald Trump's second administration, it is not only reducing its military presence and casting doubt on its security guarantees, but also renouncing its de facto (but never formally declared) leadership of the geopolitical West. That means the US is shedding a political leadership role it has exercised within Western Europe since 1945, and within Europe overall since 1990.

The obvious corollary is that Europe will be on its own, left to resolve its geopolitical problems and challenges by itself. Yet providing its own geopolitical leadership is not something Europe has done since the beginning of the 20th century. Its efforts to rise to the occasion therefore merit close attention.

"Europe" does not mean only the European Union. The EU undoubtedly plays a central role in economic affairs, underpinning a common market and customs union, a shared currency and central bank, a supranational legal and regulatory framework, and, above all, robust external trading relationships. But NATO, even in its European and Canadian dimension alone, also remains indispensable to the continent's security—even if it will be far weaker without the participation of the world's premier superpower.

A big question remains, however: Who is supposed to lead this fragile, politically unfinished entity? No single European power has the means to do so on its own. None has the necessary scale in terms of territory and population, financial strength, or technological and economic potential.

Moreover, two other intangibles are required for effective governance: a long historical tradition of providing regional leadership and a population that is broadly committed to the European project. As matters stand, only France and Germany can be said to check these boxes. Most other member states might be able to check one, but not both. Without the Franco-German partnership, the idea of European leadership is dead on arrival.

But America's withdrawal from Europe poses a particular challenge for Germany, especially in the context of today's military buildup and the strengthening of neo-nationalist forces across Europe—including in Germany itself. For decades, the US military presence reassured many Europeans, not least Germany's former wartime adversaries, who feared a resurgence of German power. This factor, too, will be absent in the future, requiring Germany to show even greater sensitivity toward its own history. Leading without dominating will mean striking a careful balance.

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Europe's progress has always been driven by joint initiatives, most of which were developed by France and Germany. Under pressure from Russian aggression—which has reached its full expression in the ongoing war against Ukraine—and an increasingly hostile US administration, the immediate priority is to create a European Defense Union. Yet given this need, and the indispensable role of Franco-German leadership in meeting it, the breakdown of the joint Franco-German Future Combat Air System (FCAS) project should be treated like a five-alarm fire. If that failure is a preview of what is to come, Europe is already doomed.

Competition is often said to be good for business. In the context of the Franco-German relationship, however, this is true only if competition is grounded in a solid foundation of mutual trust. Otherwise, it can all too easily become mutually destructive. Given the current geopolitical and strategic environment, that is the last thing Europe can afford.

Unfortunately, we now have politically weak governments on both sides of the Rhine. French President Emmanuel Macron has only about a year remaining in office, after which France may well elect a far-right Euroskeptic from Marine Le Pen's National Rally party. And no one can say with confidence how long German Chancellor Friedrich Merz will remain in office, given his government's dismal approval ratings and Germany's equally troubling economic indicators.

Yet this is precisely the moment when Europe needs strong leadership in both Paris and Berlin. It will take ambitious, clear-eyed, proactive, and civic-minded politicians to launch and sustain the initiatives that this moment demands—starting with a defense union.

We Europeans have been at peace for more than 80 years. But we ought to have learned by now that history can be cruel and unforgiving. No one is coming to our rescue this time. We will have to save ourselves.

7. The Missing Ingredient for European Tech Sovereignty

Author: Giorgos Verdi **Published:** Jul 7, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

BRUSSELS—In early June, the European Commission unveiled its Tech Sovereignty Package, a new policy agenda designed to strengthen Europe’s strategic autonomy through investments in AI, domestic semiconductor manufacturing, cloud infrastructure, and open-source software. While ambitious, the package is not enough. To ensure that AI and digital technologies advance the European Union’s economic and security interests requires confronting the root causes of Big Tech’s dominance over Europe’s digital economy.

The plan’s objective—to reduce the EU’s dependence on foreign technologies and, in turn, its vulnerability to external coercion—is laudable. Today, roughly 80% of the bloc’s digital technologies are imported, primarily from the United States. This has created a power imbalance that US President Donald Trump’s administration has not hesitated to exploit in pursuit of its political interests.

Yet the Commission’s plan is unlikely to shift that balance. Consider one of the package’s main goals: tripling the EU’s data-center capacity over the next 5–7 years. While expanding computing capacity is important, it will do little to foster a competitive domestic ecosystem unless Europeans capture a greater share of the economic value generated by AI.

Three American companies—Amazon, Google, and Microsoft—currently control 70% of Europe’s cloud market, while AI development is dominated by a handful of trillion-dollar US firms, including OpenAI and Anthropic, whose partnerships with Big Tech give them unparalleled access to capital and computing power. Without a concerted effort to tackle industry consolidation, most of the value created by Europe’s data-center buildout will ultimately flow back to the US.

Even if the Tech Sovereignty Package succeeds beyond expectations and helps create a new generation of fast-growing European startups, Big Tech could still use its market dominance to acquire or otherwise eliminate these challengers. Between 2010 and 2023, Big Tech companies acquired nearly 100 AI startups. Among them was DeepMind, whose 2014 purchase by Google has been widely viewed as a strategic loss for the United Kingdom, where the company was founded.

Acquisitions are only one mechanism through which dominant firms protect their position. Self-preferencing, tying, and restricting access to critical digital infrastructure can be just as effective in suppressing potential rivals. Meta’s recent attempt to block competing AI providers from accessing WhatsApp—a move that the European Commission swiftly reversed—illustrates how easy it is to undermine promising European alternatives.

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The good news is that Europe already has many of the tools it needs to prevent these outcomes. The EU’s Digital Markets Act (DMA), for example, prohibits gatekeeper platforms from engaging in unfair practices that

stifle competition from European innovators.

But the DMA has not kept pace with developments in cloud computing and AI, and political pressure from the Trump administration has discouraged robust enforcement against US firms. As long as the law is enforced only half-heartedly, European innovators will continue to compete on an uneven playing field.

Merger control is another underused instrument. Existing competition rules and national-security screening regimes already allow EU governments to prevent acquisitions that undermine strategic autonomy. In May, for example, the Netherlands blocked IBM spinoff Kyndryl's takeover of Dutch cloud provider Solvinity, citing risks to the public interest.

Other EU member states—and the European Commission—should follow this example and scrutinize acquisitions that risk absorbing Europe's most promising tech companies. Last year, Apple reportedly considered acquiring the French AI startup Mistral. Although the deal never materialized, it served as a reminder that the EU must be prepared to intervene when takeovers threaten not only competition but also its technological sovereignty.

At the same time, the Tech Sovereignty Package itself should be more ambitious. Its centerpiece, the Cloud and AI Development Act, seeks to ensure that sensitive public-sector functions—particularly those related to national security and defense—rely on European providers. But its strongest requirements apply only to a narrow range of activities, while member states retain considerable discretion over implementation. Given many governments' reluctance to provoke the Trump administration, this framework is unlikely to generate sufficient demand to foster a globally competitive European cloud industry.

Critically, Europe should also have the confidence to pursue a different innovation path from Silicon Valley's highly centralized and resource-intensive model. A growing number of experts argue that today's dominant AI paradigm may be approaching its limits, making it unwise for Europe to devote all of its resources to replicating it.

Instead, the EU should invest more heavily in areas such as physical, spatial, and so-called "frugal" AI, which aims to design systems that maximize impact while minimizing computational and energy requirements. Rather than simply imitating the American model, Europe must develop technologies that generate economic value, improve citizens' lives, and align with its sustainability goals.

By recognizing that dependence on US tech giants is both an economic challenge and a strategic vulnerability, the Tech Sovereignty Package marks a welcome shift in the EU's approach. But without equally ambitious efforts to curb market concentration and break Big Tech's hold on Europe's digital economy, it is bound to fall short.

8. In Praise of the World Cup's Little Guys

Author: Andrés Velasco

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LONDON — The inevitable was about to happen: Argentina would dispatch Cape Verde. But then, deep into extra time, wonder struck: Sidney Lopes Cabral, aged 23 but looking 17, took a pass on the left flank and, instead of lobbing the ball in search of a header, shifted direction (sending the defender skidding the wrong way) and let fly a curling wonder of a shot that ended in the farthest and most unreachable corner of the Argentine goal.

A tiny island state of around a half-million people, pitted against the world champion. A player who a few years ago was trundling the soggy fields of Germany's fifth division, now making football history. Even the most hard-bitten of Albiceleste fans had to admit it was a moment of beauty.

This World Cup began with a grudge: by expanding the field from 32 to 48 teams, too many minnows had been allowed in, muttered old-time football hands. Cape Verde? Curaçao? Haiti? Uzbekistan? Who had ever heard of these teams?

Yet Cape Verde was unbeaten in the group stage. Curaçao drew against an Ecuadorian squad led by Chelsea star Moisés Caicedo. The Democratic Republic of the Congo (a vast country but a minnow in football terms) managed to tie Cristiano Ronaldo's Portugal and gave England a run for its money.

And that was far from the end of it: Paraguay sent mighty Germany home; Morocco disposed of the Netherlands' clockwork orange; and Norway, which may be filthy rich but is still tiny, eliminated five-time winner Brazil. So far, this has been the little guys' World Cup.

In a world of great-power rivalry and hyper-scaling tech behemoths, you would be forgiven for thinking that the bulky bully always has the edge. But you would be wrong.

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Start with business. A quarter-century ago, Google was a minnow; Meta and Tesla were yet to be born. One-third of the 100 largest Nasdaq-listed firms were not publicly traded in 2000. As the players sweat in the American heat, new companies are no doubt being launched that will one day displace today's hyper-scalers.

Which countries have been wild economic successes in that quarter-century? Little guys Singapore, Botswana, and the Republic of Ireland surely belong on the list. Relax the definition of wild success, and New Zealand, Panama, and Uruguay make the cut. Relax the definition of minnows (it has nearly 15 million people), and Rwanda earns the right to be included. And don't forget tiny Guyana, which, thanks to oil, has been growing at over 35% per year since 2020!

Small countries have the same advantages as small companies: they can be nimble and bold. In a world of polarization and political divisions, they often find it easier than the big guys to agree on common goals and adopt reasonable policies—especially when next door lie countries that are both large and threatening.

On the little guy's fate depends another crucial feature of life: uncertainty. We tend to think uncertainty is bad, with predictability implying serenity. But, again, that is not so. Uncertainty turns out to be like perfume: a little bit is often necessary, though too much courts disaster.

Imagine learning on the day you turn 12 that decades later you would be awarded the Nobel Prize. Would you still strive sufficiently to make the prophecy come true? Or imagine that on the same day you were told that at 15 you would be struck by an incurable disease. Would those three years be more enjoyable than if you had remained uncertain about your prospects?

As every student of game theory knows, nuclear deterrence is predicated on the existence of uncertainty. It is the chance, however small, that the other side will be crazy enough to press the nuclear button that keeps my side from threatening to do the same thing.

Competition in business operates on the same logic. A large incumbent firm may have the run of the market. But as long as there are few barriers to entry and the market remains what economists call contestable, the small probability that a small new firm will challenge keeps the incumbent from raising prices too much or becoming flabby and inefficient.

Successful democratic politics is also built on the chance that the little guy may beat the odds and succeed. If an incumbent party is doing so badly in the polls that the chances of reelection are nil, then its incentives to govern well become vanishingly small. If put in that position, more than a few politicians will choose to loot the state coffers and run.

A similar logic applies to those out of power. If I belong to a minnow opposition party, the small chance that we will be in power soon is what keeps me from proposing popular yet stupid policies that would bankrupt the state and wreck the economy. Should our party surprisingly find itself in office, we would have to deal with the consequences.

In the end, Cape Verde did not prevail. Another miracle of a shot gave Argentina the final lead. But never mind. Cape Verdeans had exulted in their two hours of hope. And so had the world. There is joy—and profit—to be had in the thought that the little guy can win.

9. Inside Ukraine's Game-Changing Drone Industry

Author: Yuriy Gorodnichenko

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BERKELEY/KYIV—If necessity is the mother of innovation, Ukraine's military technology industry, particularly drone production, is Exhibit A. When Russia first attacked Ukraine in 2014, drones were used mostly for reconnaissance. Ukrainian firms developed many models, but production was limited and mainly geared to the civilian sector. Today, Ukrainian drones are central to the country's ability to hold off a much larger aggressor, and Ukraine's development and procurement processes may hold lessons for NATO's leaders as they discuss rearmament at their Ankara summit this week.

The rapid development of Ukraine's defense industries since Russia's full-scale invasion in 2022 was an adaptation to chronic shortages of munitions and other matériel. In 2022, Ukraine produced barely a thousand drones (volunteers imported about 9,000); by 2024, output had skyrocketed to 1.7–2.2 million. Another three million were produced in 2025, and seven million are planned for this year. There are now over 500 domestic drone producers. Some can produce roughly 1.5 million drones per year, and three are among the top 100 producers in the world.

The supply of drones to the army and the training of drone operators initially depended entirely on volunteers, such as Victory Drones. Even now, volunteers play a major role in providing drones and other supplies to the armed forces. For example, the Come Back Alive foundation plans to procure 16,500 long-range drones this year, worth \$34 million.

The industry is highly decentralized and extremely heterogenous. Some producers are huge. The long-range Liutyi strike drone was developed by Antonov, the company that produced the world's largest aircraft. Other producers assemble drones in kitchens and garages from components purchased on AliExpress and use 3D printers to make spare parts. Soldiers often update or repair drones themselves.

The products range from small reconnaissance devices and first-person-view (FPV) drones carrying the equivalent of a hand grenade, to large machines that can deliver several hundred kilograms of cargo to the frontlines or "sanction" Russian oil infrastructure, logistics, and military assets. Ukrainian firms also produce drone detectors, electronic warfare systems, and other anti-drone devices—from simple net throwers to automated systems that can locate and intercept enemy drones with little or no human intervention.

The spectrum of products meets diverse needs, from patrolling the kill zone at the frontline—currently about 50 kilometers (31 miles) wide—to destroying Russian supply lines (100–300 kilometers from the frontline) to hitting production facilities more than 1,000 kilometers inside Russian territory. Production of middle-range strike drones, interceptor drones, and land drones increased significantly in 2025 (during the first six months of 2026, Ukraine's army implemented over 50,000 logistic and evacuation missions with land drones).

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The industry is highly dynamic: constant communication between producers and army units means that prototypes are tested and deployed in a few months or even weeks. Although Russia often reverse-engineers

Ukrainian technologies and starts producing drones at scale, Ukrainian military leaders claim to have 50% more FPV drones than the Russians.

That is no accident. Although the industry's initial growth spurt was truly grass-roots, government policies have since provided significant support. In 2023, the government created the Brave1 cluster, which unites producers, researchers, military personnel, and investors in order to streamline the production and delivery of equipment needed at the frontlines. The government provides seed grants to innovative projects, helps Ukrainian producers to register their innovations, and connects them with users of their products. Producers can also report bureaucratic obstacles.

In June 2025, the government launched the DOT-Chain procurement platform. Army brigades can place orders for munitions there, and the State Logistics Operator (DOT, which runs military procurement) can fill the orders. The platform includes a reward program: the more enemy targets a brigade destroys, the more additional drones it can receive from the government. As of February 2026, DOT-Chain offered some 470 products from 135 producers, including drones and electronic warfare systems.

A few months later, the government launched a special tax regime for defense producers called Defence City, offering tax breaks, support for relocation or protection of premises if needed, and a simplified export procedure. By June 2026, 31 companies with total revenue of about \$2 billion had registered.

Restarting weapons exports, a step announced early this year, could also help Ukraine's military technology industry. Exports effectively stopped in February 2022, but in 2024 weapons producers started lobbying for reopening. With the government unable to procure everything producers can manufacture, exports would provide additional revenues to scale up production to meet Army demands.

Returning to the international market would also allow joint ventures with European producers to be established in Ukraine. To leverage Western capital and access to safe production, Ukrainian firms already have joint ventures with enterprises in Germany, Canada, the United Kingdom, and elsewhere. Localizing such ventures would keep human capital and technology at home.

This is especially important given the domestic industry's shortage of qualified personnel, particularly engineers. And localization is needed to address another major problem facing drone producers: reliance on imported components, which are sourced mostly from China. According to research by the Lviv-based IRON defense technology cluster, localization currently stands at 85% for frames and structural components, 14% for cameras, and 12% for engines. Some producers within the Brave1 cluster have started manufacturing cameras to replace Chinese products, while other firms produce drone-borne munitions.

The bigger problem is that drones are not a panacea. While a special army branch, Unmanned Systems Forces, has destroyed Russian assets worth \$40 billion since it was established about a year ago, drones cannot replace personnel and do not make "traditional" weapons obsolete.

But even if drones are not a magic bullet, they have transformed geopolitics. When Russia uses drones to test the defenses of Poland or Romania, or fly over critical German infrastructure, neither NATO nor individual countries respond for fear of escalation. Similarly, Iran has demonstrated how low-cost drone-based warfare can upend conventional tactics.

Ukraine's rapid emergence as a leader in drone technologies can help NATO and Gulf countries defend themselves against Russia and Iran. But Ukraine urgently needs help, too. Drones are no substitute for the air-defense systems, long-range missiles, and other conventional weapons Ukraine needs to end the war.

10. Just Say No to Remote Work

Author: Michael R. Strain **Published:** Jul 7, 2026 **Link:** [View Original](#)

WASHINGTON, DC—My advice for the two million young people who graduated with bachelor's degrees over the last few months and are just starting their careers: Go to work—not just figuratively, but literally. If you have a job that allows hybrid work arrangements, do not use them. Instead, be at your desk five (or six!) days per week. And if your job is fully remote, start looking for a new one.

I was giving the same advice back in 2021, when millions of white-collar workers had decided that remote work was one feature of the COVID-19 lockdowns they wanted to keep. At the time, we didn't have much evidence on the labor-market effects of working from home. But we do now.

In a new study, economists Natalia Emanuel and Emma Harrington, the authors of *In Person: How Working Together Fuels Creativity, Productivity, and Growth*, and Harvard economist Amanda Pallais calculate that the unemployment rate among college graduates under 29 years of age was 1.3 percentage points higher in 2025 than in 2019 (just before the pandemic and the four-fold increase in people working remotely). Among older college graduates, the unemployment rate increased by 0.4 percentage points over the same period.

To explain this divergence, the authors compare the unemployment rates of workers in jobs that are easily done remotely (for example, software engineers) with jobs that are hard to do remotely (such as mechanical engineers). They find that remote work is responsible for nearly two-thirds of the unemployment gap between college graduates under 29 and older graduates. Moreover, their results hold up even when they control for each occupation's exposure to automation by generative AI tools.

These findings jibe with a second new study. Economists Peter John Lambert and Yannick Schindler examined four Anglophone countries, including the United States, and found that the rise of remote work after the pandemic led to a shift in both hiring and vacancies that favored more senior workers over those with just a few years of experience. Moreover, they show that the arrival and increased use of AI tools have had no effect on the decline in the demand for junior talent.

I hope these findings will serve as a source of motivation for young, college-educated workers. It is very much in their interest to go to work—physically. Employers are increasingly turning away from inexperienced workers for remote roles because such arrangements require relatively more supervision and greater effort to build new knowledge and skills. Meeting these needs is much harder—and therefore costlier—when a newly hired worker is at home on the couch, interacting with colleagues over Zoom.

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With an in-person setting, by contrast, newly minted graduates will be faster to develop their emotional intelligence, which is crucial for success in many occupations. Reading body language and changes in facial expressions and tones of voice are crucial skills that cannot be easily learned over Zoom. Collegiality and group cohesion is best created through repeated physical interaction. For inexperienced workers trying to build

professional networks and learn about new opportunities for advancement, unplanned meetings at the espresso machine or in the parking lot can be invaluable.

Yet many people in their early professional years are depriving themselves of these advantages. Some are doing so to maximize their leisure time or out of an exaggerated sense of the value they provide to their employers. But I suspect that the trend can largely be explained by something more prosaic: Employers often offer hybrid work as a benefit, so young workers take it. They should resist this temptation. Just because remote work is on offer doesn't mean it has to be used.

What about workers with more than a handful of years of experience? Here, the right solution for most may not be to revert to the world of 2019. In my judgment, the costs to workers of a hybrid arrangement can be substantially mitigated by strong existing workplace relationships built on sustained in-person interactions.

Unlike workers in their early 20s, more experienced workers often have actual responsibilities in their personal lives—caring for children or aging parents, for instance—that they must balance against their professional responsibilities. This is partly why people value remote work in the first place.

From the perspective of employers, hybrid work does seem to damage productivity less than fully remote work; and in some circumstances, it may even boost productivity. Remote work also has been very beneficial for people with disabilities. Employment rates for this group are much higher than in the years prior to the pandemic. The economists Nicholas Bloom, Gordon B. Dahl, and Dan-Olof Rooth find that the post-pandemic increase in work from home explains over two-thirds of the increase in full-time employment for people with disabilities. The rise of remote work is analogous to the adoption of a new technology that allows businesses to benefit more fully from the creativity, effort, and skills of people with disabilities.

Still, even for more experienced professionals, remote work has gone too far. The balance will shift back toward in-person arrangements if the labor market softens and the unemployment rate starts to rise.

Given the many risks and drawbacks, the message younger workers need to hear is not nuanced: Be physically present. Work hard. Knock on doors. Get to the office before your supervisor arrives, and don't leave work before he or she does.

First impressions matter, and like the background on a Zoom call, they can be blurred and distorted unless you are standing face to face.